

PHIL305: Philosophy of Mind 7214 — Fall 2026

Instructor: Montague Reynolds, PhD | **Office:** Elizabeth Hall Rm. 104 | **Email:** mreynolds1@stetson.edu | **Phone:** 206-234-3477 | **Office Hours:** By appointment

Meeting Times: Mon, Wed 2:30–3:45 PM | **Location:** Flagler Hall 213 | **Enrollment:** 10-15 students

Course Overview

This course introduces advanced philosophical thinking about the mind. We use a comprehensive exploration of contemporary philosophy of mind as our primary text, examining foundational questions: What is the mind? How does it relate to the body? What is consciousness? How do mental states represent the world? Who else has a mind? How do we know ourselves?

We approach these questions through rigorous conceptual analysis, engaging with physicalism, externalism, theories of consciousness, and the metaphysics of mental causation. The course bridges classical problems (the mind-body problem, other minds, self-knowledge) with contemporary research in philosophy of mind.

Core Thesis: Understanding the mind requires integrating multiple perspectives—from physical science to subjective experience, from mental content to consciousness, from individual minds to minds in a shared world. Philosophy of mind cultivates the intellectual virtue of conceptual precision: the ability to define terms rigorously, identify hidden assumptions, and reason carefully through competing theories.

Pedagogical Approach: You will engage with philosophy of mind by: reading and analyzing foundational texts carefully • designing thought experiments that test philosophical claims • creating AI philosopher personas that model sophisticated objections • collaborating with peers to evaluate competing theories • reflecting critically on your own intuitions about mental phenomena. You don't just understand the hard problem abstractly; you work through concrete cases. You don't just read about intentionality; you explore how mental content grounds meaning.

Learning Outcomes

By course end, you will be able to:

- Identify and articulate core problems in philosophy of mind (mind-body problem, consciousness, mental content, other minds)
 - Recognize thought experiments as tools for testing philosophical theories and evaluate their effectiveness
 - Apply philosophical theories (physicalism, functionalism, externalism, etc.) to novel mental phenomena
 - Design and create Socratic dialogues using AI philosopher personas that model rigorous objections
 - Design thought experiments that illuminate problems in philosophy of mind
 - Reflect critically on your own mental phenomena (perception, thought, consciousness) through philosophical analysis
 - Collaborate effectively in philosophical discussions and theory comparison
 - Articulate philosophical positions clearly in writing and discussion, with careful attention to conceptual precision
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Required Materials

Primary Text: Berit Brogaard, *On Romantic Love: Simple Truths about a Complex Emotion*, Philosophy in Action (Oxford University Press, 2015). Core chapters: Introduction, 1–13, Conclusion

Secondary Readings:

- Bayne, Tim. *Philosophy of Mind: An Introduction*. Routledge, Taylor & Francis Group, 2022.
- Classical works in philosophy of mind (Descartes, Locke, Hume selections)
- Contemporary articles on specific topics (provided weekly)
- Assigned readings via course management.

Technology & Platforms: Claude AI (Philosopher personas, web interface) • Course management: Canvas • Thought experiment design tools (provided)

Course Structure

Format: Lecture/Discussion | **Enrollment:** ~24–26 students | **Meeting times:** Mon/Wed 2:30–3:45 PM

Assignment Breakdown

Assignment	#	Points Each	Total	% Grade
Weekly	6	20	120	38%
Theory Analyses	3	25	75	23%
Thought Experiment Sessions	3	15	45	14%
Final Project	1	80	80	25%
TOTAL	—	—	320	100%

Grade Scale: A 93–100% (297–320) | A- 90–92% (288–296) | B+ 87–89% (278–287) | B 83–86% (266–277) | B- 80–82% (256–265) | C+ 77–79% (246–255) | C 73–76% (234–245)

Assignment Details:

- **Weekly Reflections (6 × 20 pts):** 500–750 word responses to assigned readings, identifying key problems and your intuitions
 - **Theory Analyses (3 × 25 pts):** Group projects analyzing a philosophical theory (e.g., physicalism, functionalism, externalism) with objections and responses
 - **Thought Experiment Sessions (3 × 15 pts):** Individual reflections on collaborative thought experiment workshops exploring mental phenomena
 - **Final Project (80 pts):** ~2500–3000 words synthesizing three theories applied to a single mental phenomenon, tracking how your understanding evolved
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Course Schedule — Fall 2026

Week 1 (Aug 20, 22): Introduction: A Map of the Mind | Readings: Introduction | Due: None

Week 2 (Aug 26, 29): Marks of the Mental | Readings: Ch. 1 | Due: **Weekly #1** (500–750 words): Identify what makes something "mental"; reflect on your intuition) | Pts: **20**

Week 3 (Sept 3, 5): Physicalism | Readings: Ch. 2 | Due: Research for Theory Analysis #1 begins

Week 4 (Sept 9, 12): How to Be a Physicalist | Readings: Ch. 3 | Due: **Weekly #2** (500–750 words); **Theory Analysis #1** (Fri 9/12): Physicalism—arguments for/against | Pts: **20 25**

Week 5 (Sept 16, 19): Perception | Readings: Ch. 4 | Due: **Thought Experiment Session 1 Reflection** (250–400 words, Wed 9/16); **Theory Analysis #1 Documentation** (group) | Pts: **15 25**

Week 6 (Sept 23, 26): Thought | Readings: Ch. 5 | Due: **Weekly #3** (500–750 words): What makes a thought a thought? Reflect on intentionality) | Pts: **20**

Week 7 (Sept 30, Oct 3): Grounding Intentionality | Readings: Ch. 6 | Due: **Weekly #4** (500–750 words): How do mental states come to be about things?) | Pts: **20**

Week 8 (Oct 7, 10): Externalism & the Extended Mind | Readings: Ch. 7 | Due: **Weekly #5** (500–750 words); **Theory Analysis #2** (Fri 10/10): Externalism—mind beyond the brain | Pts: **20 25**

Week 9 (Oct 14, 17): The Metaphysics of Consciousness | Readings: Ch. 8 | Due: **Thought Experiment Session 2 Reflection** (250–400 words, Wed 10/14); **Theory Analysis #2 Documentation** (group) | Pts: **15 25**

Week 10 (Oct 21, 24): Theories of Consciousness | Readings: Ch. 9 | Due: Research for Theory Analysis #3 begins

Week 11 (Oct 28, 31): Mental Causation | Readings: Ch. 10 | Due: Theory Analysis #3 research complete

Week 12 (Nov 4, 7): Other Minds | Readings: Ch. 11 | Due: **Weekly #6** (500–750 words); **Theory Analysis #3** (Fri 11/7): Consciousness—how to explain subjective experience | Pts: **20 25**

Week 13 (Nov 11, 14): Self-Knowledge | Readings: Ch. 12 | Due: **Thought Experiment Session 3 Reflection** (250–400 words, Wed 11/11); **Theory Analysis #3 Documentation** (group) | Pts: **15 25**

Week 14 (Nov 18, 20): The Self | Readings: Ch. 13 | Due: None

Nov 24–Dec 1: THANKSGIVING BREAK

Week 15 (Dec 2, 4): Synthesis & Final Project Workshop | Readings: Conclusion + review | Due: None (draft encouraged)

Week 16 (Dec 9, 11): Course Conclusion | Readings: Review as needed | Due: **FINAL PROJECT** (by 11:59 PM Wed 12/11): ~2500–3000 words • Three theories applied to one phenomenon • Intuition tracking and synthesis | Pts: **80**

Final Thought

Philosophy of mind asks: What is it like to have a mind? How can we understand the most intimate aspect of our existence through reason? In this course, we pursue conceptual clarity about consciousness, intentionality, and selfhood—not as abstract exercises, but as rigorous attempts to make sense of what we are. We read carefully, think deeply, and challenge our assumptions together. Welcome to philosophy of mind. Let's understand the mind.

See detailed calendar for week-by-week topics and readings.

Accessibility & Accommodations

If you anticipate barriers related to format or course requirements, meet with the instructor to ensure full participation. For disability-related accommodations, register with the Office of Academic Success, Accessibility Services Center, duPont-Ball Library 2nd floor (386-822-7127) and notify the instructor of your eligibility.

Honor System

Stetson University expects active student involvement and values honesty and integrity. Academic dishonesty rejects the academy's substance (learning and inquiry) and substitutes superficial externalities.

The Honor Pledge: All students subscribe to this pledge and reaffirm it by writing "pledged" before their signature on exams and papers. "As a member of Stetson University, I agree to uphold the highest standards of integrity in my academic work. I promise that I will neither give nor receive unauthorized aid on tests, papers, and assignments. When using ideas, thoughts, or

words of another in my work, I will always provide clear acknowledgement of individuals and sources. I will avoid using fraudulent, falsified, or fabricated evidence/material. I will refrain from resubmitting without authorization work for one class previously submitted for academic credit in another. I will not destroy, steal, or make inaccessible any academic resource material. By my actions and example, I will strive to promote the ideals of honesty, responsibility, trust, fairness, and respect at the heart of Stetson's Honor System."

Generative AI Use

Students may use Generative AI for certain assignments. All AI-generated content must be clearly labeled and attributed to the AI source, with disclosure of your role in curation/editing. Misrepresenting AI-generated content as original work or failing to attribute sources is a serious academic integrity violation. Discuss uncertainties with the instructor.

AI language models (e.g., ChatGPT) may be used for any assignment with appropriate citation. You are responsible for fact-checking AI-generated statements.

Title IX

Title IX of the Educational Amendments of 1972 prohibits sex discrimination in any federally-funded educational institution. Stetson does not tolerate sex/gender-based misconduct, discrimination, harassment, violence, intimate partner violence, or stalking.

Report incidents to: Executive Director & Title IX Coordinator (www.Stetson.edu/reportit or 386-822-7960) | Deputy Title IX Coordinator for Students (titleix@stetson.edu or 386-822-7205) | Public Safety (386-822-7300). **Confidential resources:** Student Counseling Services, Student Health Service, or University Chaplain (Griffith Hall).

Respect for Others

It is my intent that all students regardless of background and perspectives be well served by this course, that learning needs be addressed in and out of class, and that intrinsic value all students bring be viewed as resource, strength, and benefit. I will present materials and activities respectful of all persons. I appreciate your suggestions for improving effectiveness. Please let me know if class meetings conflict with religious events so we can arrange alternatives.

Campus Resources (FREE)

Hollis Family Student Success Center (Office of Academic Success): Study spaces • Success Coaches (time management, note-taking, test prep) • Tutoring • Writing Center • Stetson Peer Instruction (SPI) • Academic advising

Student Counseling Services Reasons to seek: stress management, test anxiety, relationship concerns, trauma, adjustment to college

Contact: 386-822-8900 | **Location:** Griffith Hall | **Hours:** Weekdays 8:00 AM–4:30 PM (closed 12:00–1:00 PM) | **Crisis (outside hours):** 386-822-8900 #5

Qualified professional counselors trained to support students through difficult transitions. Confidential and free for all enrolled students.

See also: Student grievance policies • Family Educational Rights Privacy Act • Other undergraduate student policies